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Theorising Information Literacy: Opportunities and Constraints

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ABSTRACT

Information literacy research is growing in importance but has been critiqued for remaining focused on practical topics of interest and attainment approaches to practice. Prior attempts to conceptualise information literacy have also often taken place without a comprehensive understanding of the ontological or epistemological foundations of theoretical work. The aim of this panel is to critically examine theory development and use within information literacy research through discussing the ways in which understandings of information literacy, including how it happens and how it shapes social life, are both enabled and constrained through critical, sociomaterial and discursive theoretical approaches. Providing a space to discuss and reflect on the impact of theory on information literacy scholarship, this panel creates a focal point for researchers, practitioners and students interested in the construction and advancement of conceptually rich information literacy research and practice.

KEYWORDS

Information literacy, Theory, Theoretical Frameworks, Theory Development

INTRODUCTION

Theory is a critical element of research. Providing the intellectual scaffolding that is necessary for the development, implementation, analysis, interpretation, and critical evaluation of scholarship, theory provides the concepts that are needed to describe how a phenomenon is enacted or experienced. The last twenty years marks impressive progress in the application of theory to information literacy research. Resulting in the conceptualisation of information literacy as a socially situated practice, the application of sociocultural, postmodern, and post-structuralist theoretical perspectives has enabled researchers to understand what information literacy is, how it happens and how it shapes social life. Yet, attempts are still made to conceptualise information literacy without a comprehensive understanding of the ontological or epistemological foundations of theoretical work, including its strengths or limitations. And, although literacy forms a "growth word" within the field (Larivière, Sugimoto & Cronin, 2012), theoretical advances and contributions still tend to be drowned out by the dominant provision and attainment view of information literacy practice.

This panel addresses these issues by providing an opportunity for key researchers, theorists, and practitioners in the information literacy field to discuss and reflect on the impact of theory within information literacy research through reference to a range of theories and theoretical perspectives. Examining how five conceptual approaches impact the presentation and treatment of key information literacy concepts, including learning, information and the learner, the panel further explores how the use of theory both enables and constrains the landscape of information literacy research. While the panellists recognise that information literacy is a practical field, and that theory and practice cannot be separated, we argue that there must also be space for purely conceptual information literacy reflection and development if we are to continue critically interpreting how we understand and position practice. Impetus for this panel further stems from a recognition of how information literacy is often excluded from existing theoretical consideration within the field of information science, with relevant contributions on information literacy theory, development and use often limited to Kuhlthau (Sonnenwald, 2016) or loose understandings of Freirean thought (e.g., Leckie, Given and Buschman, 2010). The stated wish to integrate more theoretical work into information literacy models and frameworks (e.g., ACRL, 2016) means that the panel will be of interest to both practitioners and researchers who are trying to extend their understanding of theoretical approaches in the field.

In focusing on theory development and use within information literacy, driving questions for this panel include:

- How do theoretical stances used within information literacy research fit with or challenge each other, including how they position information literacy as an object of research?
- Why is theory needed within information literacy research; what understandings does theory open information literacy up to and what does it close it to?

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PANEL OUTLINE

The panel will start with a brief overview of theory in relation to information literacy, centred on an analysis of theoretical information literacy research to date. After the introduction, each panellist will present a lightning talk introduction to a theoretical stance that has or could be used for studying information literacy. After each lightning talk, the moderator and panellists will then lead a short discussion on the rich palette of theoretical approaches that has emerged within information literacy research, including related to tensions about how these theories fit with or challenge each other. After this discussion, each panellist will retake the floor to present a short reflection on why theory is needed within information literacy research, including what theory opens the field up to and what it constrains, ontologically, epistemologically, and methodologically speaking. During the final part of the panel, the moderator and panellists will engage the audience with a wider discussion on the use of theory within information literacy research, including what grows or diminishes in importance when we consider theoretical rather than practical approaches to information literacy research, and ideas for future research. The audience will leave with an expanded perspective on the rich theoretical complexity that lies at the heart of information literacy research, and how this work can broaden key information science constructs.

Panelist Perspectives

Alison Hicks, UCL, UK

Alison Hicks will serve as the moderator for the panel as well as 1) introducing the topic through presenting findings from recent metanalytical work exploring information literacy theoretical development and 2) presenting concluding observations related to how theory contributes to and shapes information literacy research. Serving to contextualise panellists' contributions, the opening section will draw upon a recent literature review of theoretical information literacy to elaborate themes within the framing of empirical research and analysis to date, including tension between agency and enactment; the moral imperative of information literacy; discourse and power; marginalisation; privilege as critical reflection, and revisioning the premises on which information literacy is constructed. Providing a more nuanced understanding of the intricate layers that constitute the landscape of information literacy research, this section also sets the scene for how theory accounts for the lived experience, conditions and the arrangements that enable information literacy to be enacted. The concluding section will draw out observations about the ways in which theoretical information work can take place, including through employing broad theoretical frameworks, a central theoretical concept, and the use of theory to zoom in and out of action. This section will also look to the future by examining emerging themes within theoretical research and the silences (and their implications for teaching practices) that remain.

Professor Ola Pilerot, Swedish School of Library and Information Science, Sweden

Ola Pilerot will propose an approach grounded in ***institutional ethnography*** (e.g., Smith, 2005) for the study of information literacy. The aim of the proposal is to suggest a theoretically informed mode of inquiry that discovers how local information literacy practices are shaped through their relationships to not only the immediate context in which information literacy is enacted but also to constellations of discourses and knowledge regimes located elsewhere, in other places and times. A fundamental idea for this approach is that time and place constitute a web of what Smith (2005) describes as "the ruling relations"'. These relations contribute to coordinate activities "across and beyond local sites of everyday experience" (Smith, 2002, p. 45). Information literacy practices are thus viewed as an empirical object that should be investigated through paying attention to situated practices but also to the myriad of documents – directives, guidelines, and other texts – as well as material objects that serve as connectors and mediators between the local and the extra-local. Employing theory for investigating information literacy can be done with different purposes. In this presentation, however, theory is conceived as a device that allows for a certain explanatory perspective that guides the researcher regarding what to look for and how to describe and understand the empirical object of information literacy.

Arthur Coelho Bezerra - Brazilian Institute of Information in Science and Technology (IBICT); International Center of Information Ethics (ICIE) and Marco Schneider - Brazilian Institute of Information in Science and Technology (IBICT); Universidade Federal Fluminense (UFF); International Center of Information Ethics (ICIE)

Starting from Paulo Freire's critical pedagogy, which is used by many authors to overcome the essentially technical character of the notion of information literacy, Arthur Coelho Bezerra and Marco Schneider will draw upon ***critical theory*** to propose a deepening of one of Paolo Freire's main theoretical roots: the critique of political economy, which characterises historical materialism both as philosophical perspective and as a scientific dialectical method. The goal is to stimulate the formulation of critical diagnoses of the informational environment aiming at the autonomy of "literate" individuals. The dominant notion of information literacy, focused on the instrumental use of information to solve immediate problems, is the result of an ideology that submits individuals' competences to the demands of the capitalist world of work, instead of promoting a libertarian education towards people's autonomy. Understanding the ideological components of information regimes is essential in order to criticise the mechanisms of exploitation and oppression that are manifested in what Freire calls "banking education", which are also reflected in

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the digital ecosystem dominated by big tech corporations that profit from disinformation and scientific denialism. This contribution ends by proposing a path to reach a "theoretically informed praxis" that is based on the critical evaluation and ethical use of information.

Professor Noora Hirvonen, University of Oulu, Finland
Noora Hirvonen will address information literacy from the viewpoint of ***mediated discourse theory*** (MDT) which can be characterised as a discursive theory of human action. MDT offers a way to view the actions of humans as occurring at the intersection of multimodal discourses in specific time-place; people with their unique histories; and mutually produced social arrangements. This view of social action highlights that although action would be taken by specific individuals at specific times and places, they are always dependent on multiple elements, including other persons, times, and places. MDT invites a way to view information literacy practices as constituted from chains of small-scale actions taken by individual people but shaped by various material and symbolic tools, people, and discourses circulating through them. The approach may help in conceptualising information literacy as both individual and collective and as both historical and situated. As such, it can be useful in addressing the tensions between the individual and community-focused understandings of information literacy. Hirvonen draws from MDT and its methodological extension, nexus analysis, to argue that theory in information literacy research is essential in interrogating our taken-for-granted understandings of reality and identifying ways to change it.

Professor Jutta Haider, Swedish School of Library and Information Science, Sweden
Jutta Haider will consider information literacy through the lens of ***sociomateriality***. Increasingly, the evaluation of information and other information practices, as well as much of the public debate, are co-produced by a rapidly evolving, ubiquitous digital information infrastructure dominated by a few global, multi-sided platforms and other corporate actors. Sociomateriality considers the material aspects of information literacy and offers a multi-faceted understanding of how practices, technologies and information literacies mutually constitute each other. After briefly outlining the main features of sociomateriality, Haider proposes a punk approach to sociomateriality to consider how today's information infrastructures are largely beyond the control of society and individual users. A punk approach to sociomateriality resists the fetishisation of technology and technological progress that shrouds information technologies in such mystery that their exploration threatens to become the privilege of a minority. It creates an understanding based on playful, even angry, or defiant encounters with technology configurations, and is not intimidated by the limits set by corporate information infrastructures, nor constrained by the pursuit of frictionless conceptual consistency. A punk approach to a sociomaterial understanding of information literacy is a "good enough" tactic, where the researcher performs and resists sociomateriality through their own actions. As this presentation will argue, a punk approach to a sociomaterial understanding of information literacy takes materiality and co-constitution seriously while explicitly foregrounding power relations. In this way, a broader understanding of harms becomes possible, hopefully including a rethinking of information literacy that includes opportunities and resources for refusal.

Veronica Johansson, Swedish School of Library and Information Science, Sweden
Veronica Johansson will elaborate on critical dimensions of information literacy through the application of ***critical design theories***. Critical design theories problematise uncritical replication of social norms and values – so-called affirmative (or problem-solving) design – as perpetuating status quo and power imbalances. But they also offer tools for oppositional critical (problem-finding) design, intended to support critical awareness and possibilities of action among individuals and society (Dunne and Raby, 2002; Malpass, 2012). The resulting critical literacy-critical design synthesis aligns with poststructuralist and sociotechnical views and offers novel expansions on several levels. Conceptually, critical literacy is extended to competencies to identify, contest, and transform limited, biased representations in information and information systems with associated power effects. Empirically, studies are guided towards the situated intersections of material embodiment (as design) and social enactment through which the mediation of values and power in information construction, use, and exchange can be surfaced and addressed. Finally, and practically, it points to not only responsibilities but concrete means for information actors to forge critically attuned design alternatives. For discussion, examples of such critical information design practices as e.g., context-transfer, hybridity, and cut-up is offered.

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